amounts of money in people's and business' pockets, thus awakening demand and lifting spirits of the businesses to hire more people. He would have advocated that in a major recession, only the government has the resources to prod society back on its feet. For India, this would be a major challenge, since we were still not a 'rich economy' and several billion pockets would need to be filled, causing extreme strain on the exchequer. The solution, as the members of the COVID-19 Economic Response Task Force concurred, lay somewhere in the middle of the two theories. It was certainly clear to them though that this could possibly be the greatest economic crisis India would see since Independence.

And hence, the immediate relief package that India would give out would include some cash handouts by way of direct benefit transfers to limited, vulnerable groups. Money would be transferred to Women Jan-Dhan account holders, 8.69 crore farmers, widows and handicapped persons under the poverty line. Wages of those employed in the government's rural employment guarantee scheme and pensioners would be increased. Families below the poverty line would also be given free gas cylinders for the next three months. A majority of the immediate stimulus would go towards supply of free food grains—5 kg of rice/wheat and 1 kg pulses to 80 crore people, in addition to what they were already receiving. Insurance cover for frontline workers would be increased and some initiatives for workers of the organized and construction sectors would also be carved out.

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Meanwhile, the frequent meetings that Dr Paul and PSA Prof. VijayRaghavan were having, right from January 2020, were now expanded to include 18 more members comprising scientists, doctors, modellers, academicians and bureaucrats. Constituted by the PMO, it was called the R&D Task Force for COVID-19 Research and was primarily responsible for providing sound scientific advice on aspects such as spread of the virus, the role of science, the direction that the country should take to shape its response and so on. They were also responsible for closely studying emerging evidence and responses by other nations hit by the virus.

At around the same time, ICMR constituted a National Task Force (NTF) too, chaired by Dr Paul and co-chaired by secretary (Department of Health) and Dr Bhargava to focus on epidemiological matters related to the